

Family Council Readiness Guide

A private preparation note for enterprising families before a governance conversation.

Purpose of the Council

A family council should not become a second management meeting. Its purpose is to protect family alignment, clarify ownership expectations, and create a trusted space for conversations that affect the family system.

Before the first meeting, agree on what the council can decide, what it can recommend, and what must remain with the board, owners, or management.

Suggested First Agenda

1. What decisions are currently being made informally?
2. Which family topics create the most confusion or repeated side conversations?
3. What information should family shareholders receive, and how often?
4. Which topics should be handled by the board, management, owners, or family council?
5. What rhythm would be realistic for the next six months?

Roles to Clarify

Chair: protects the agenda and tone of the meeting.

Family members: prepare honestly and speak from responsibility, not only preference.

Advisor or facilitator: helps the family separate people, roles, and decisions.

Recorder: captures agreements, open questions, owners, and next steps without turning the meeting into a transcript.

Readiness Signals

A family is ready to begin when it can name the topics it has been avoiding, agree that informal decision-making is no longer sufficient, and commit to a meeting rhythm even when the first conversation feels imperfect.